

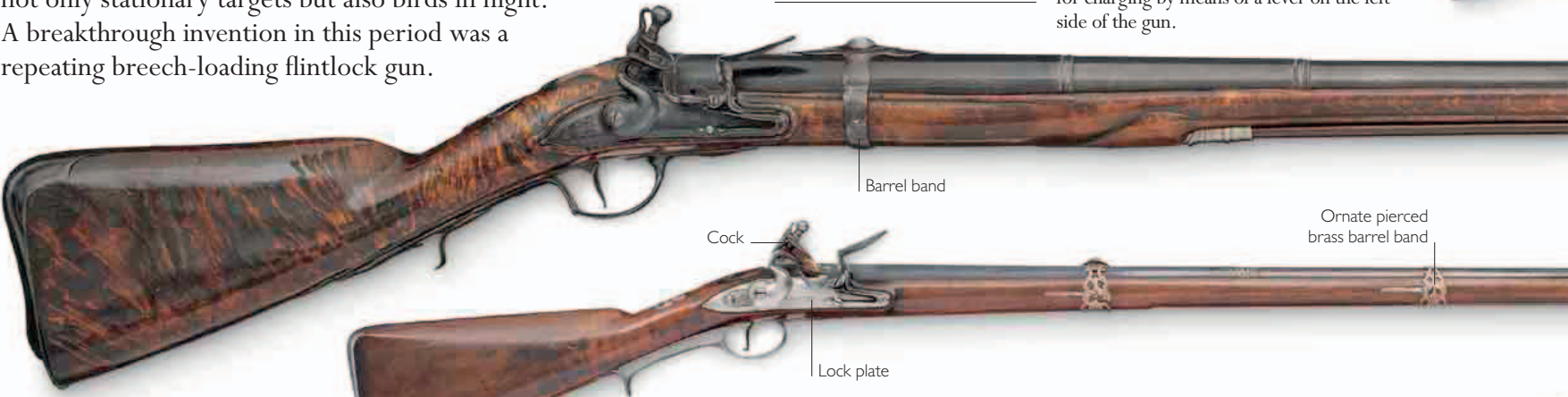
EUROPEAN HUNTING GUNS

By the beginning of the 18th century, gunmakers in most parts of Europe were making sporting firearms in popular styles based originally on French designs. The flintlock now predominated in most of Europe. While a more austere style emerged, the remaining ornamentation became more sophisticated, with minimal decorative inlaying and emphasis placed on the natural qualities of the wood. The flintlock mechanism in these guns had become efficient enough that sportsmen could shoot not only stationary targets but also birds in flight. A breakthrough invention in this period was a repeating breech-loading flintlock gun.



▲ ITALIAN REPEATING FLINTLOCK
Date c.1690
Origin Italy
Barrel 35in (89cm)
Caliber .53in (13.5mm)

Italian gunmaker Michele Lorenzoni lived in Florence from 1683 to 1733 and invented an early form of repeating flintlock breech-loader. Paired magazines, one for powder and the other for shot, were located in the butt, and the breechblock was rotated for charging by means of a lever on the left side of the gun.



▲ FLINTLOCK SPORTING GUN
Date 1700
Origin England
Barrel 55in (139.5cm)
Caliber .75in (19mm)

This full-stocked sporting gun, by John Shaw, bears a remarkable resemblance to military firearms of the time. However, the attention that has been paid to the selection of the wood for its stock immediately sets it apart, as does the care that has been lavished on its finishing.

▲ ENGLISH SPORTING GUN
Date 1760
Origin England
Barrel 36in (91.4cm)
Caliber .68in (17.3mm)

The gunmaker Benjamin Griffin worked in fashionable Bond Street in London from 1735 to 1770, and was joined in 1750 by his son Joseph. Both father and son were renowned for their excellent pistols and long guns. Many of these, such as the example seen here, were graced with ornate engraving to the metal parts, decorative brasswork, and silver-wire inlay.



▲ ENGLISH FLINTLOCK SPORTING GUN
Date 1690
Origin England
Barrel 38in (96.5cm)
Caliber .75in (19mm)

Walnut stock

Andrew Dolep was a Dutch gunmaker who settled in London and set up shop near Charing Cross. He produced this magnificent flintlock—its walnut stock extensively inlaid with silver wire—toward the end of his career. Dolep is credited with the design of the “Brown Bess” musket (see p.53), which this gun resembles.

Walnut stock